



“WE HAVE MADE GOOD PROGRESS IN ADVANCING THE BROADER AGENDA”

Harsh Vardhan Shringla, Chief Coordinator for India's G20 presidency, holds forth on the country's priorities and more

BY **ANAND ADHIKARI** • PHOTO BY **MILIND SHELTE**

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CO-ORDINATING RESOURCES,

personnel, logistics and delegates from across the G20 (Group of 20) member states, invitee countries and international organisations for the 200 meetings in over 50 cities around the country across 32 different work-streams and spread over a year is no mean feat. But former foreign secretary and diplomat Harsh Vardhan Shringla, who is currently the Chief Coordinator for India's G20 presidency, seems to be pulling off the task with aplomb.

During a recent visit to Mumbai to attend a discussion at Gateway House, a foreign policy-focussed think tank, the 61-year-old Shringla, in a conversation with *Business Today*, spoke about India's priorities during its G20 presidency, the progress achieved at various meetings held so far, and the role the country is playing in tackling issues of global importance. Edited excerpts:



As the Chief Coordinator for India's G20 presidency, how do you plan to address the challenges posed by the current global geopo-

litical tensions, and the complexities of India-China relations?

Prime Minister Narendra Modi emphasised that our presidency should be inclusive, ambitious, decisive, and action-oriented. The effort has been to address today's global challenges. In our broad priorities, we have not only factored in the views of our partners in the G20, but also the hopes and aspirations of the developing world, the Global South. Our focus spans from accelerating resilient and inclusive growth to advancing SDGs (Sustainable Development Goals), embracing digital transformation and public infrastructure, fostering sustainable development and addressing lifestyle issues for the environment and climate change, reforming multi-lateral institutions, and promoting women-led development.



As we cross the halfway mark of India's G20 presidency, could you highlight some of the successes that have been achieved so far?

G20 meetings are still ongoing, but in general, we have made good progress in advancing the G20's broader agenda. The G20 has adopted India's seven-year SDG plan. The widespread acceptance of digital public infrastructure as an empowering tool has also been impressive. One critical question is, how can the G20 support developing countries in achieving their developmental goals, particularly through digital public infrastructure (DPI)?

India stands at the forefront in this context, with the PM highlighting in Bali (G20 Indonesia 2022) that 40 per cent of the world's real-time payment transactions are facilitated through UPI. Our nation leads as one of the most active users of DPI, effectively empowering people at the grassroots level.

In the 11 years from 2010 to 2021 using a digital ID (Aadhaar), India has not only increased banking penetration from below 30 per cent to about 79 per cent, we have also been able to close the gender gap in banking. As the PM emphasised, there are 4 billion people worldwide without identity cards, and 1.4 billion lack bank accounts. In this regard, our